subjects, he would fare poorly in a state created as the homeland for South Asian Muslims.[11] Consequently, almost two months after the independence of India and Pakistan, he still had not acceded to either state.

Hari Singh's vacillation, however, soon came to an end. In October 1947, a tribal rebellion broke out in Poonch, in the western reaches of Kashmir. Sensing an opportunity to exploit the situation, the government of Pakistan quickly entered the fray.[12] The Pakistanis sent in regular troops disguised as local tribesmen to aid the rebels. With Pakistani logistical, material, and organizational support, the rebels moved rapidly toward Srinagar, the summer capital of J&K, plundering and pillaging along the way. The maharaja's forces proved utterly incapable of stemming the onslaught.[13] Hari Singh, now in a state of panic, appealed to India for assistance. Prime Minister Nehru agreed to help, but only if two conditions were met. First, Kashmir would have to formally accede to India. Second, the Kashmiri people would have to approve the accession at a later date, once calm had been restored. Meanwhile, Nehru would accept the imprimatur of Sheikh Mohammed Abdullah, the leader of the Jammu and Kashmir National Conference, Kashmir's largest popular and secular political party. Only when he received Abdullah's explicit assent did Nehru proceed with accession.[14] Almost immediately, Indian troops were flown into Srinagar,[15] where they managed to stop the tribal advance, but not before the rebels had managed to seize about a third of the territory of the state.[16]

Despite periods of intense fighting, the situation on the ground changed little. Pakistan-backed forces, which included Hazara and Afridi tribesmen, paramilitary elements from organizations such as the Muslim League National Guards and regular Pakistan Army personnel had made quick work of Maharaja Hari Singh's troops. They then launched a three-pronged assault on a communications center located at Uri and damaged the power grid to Srinagar. On November 7, the Indian military counterattacked. They secured the Srinagar airfield, captured the town of Baramula, and by November 13 had managed to restore power to Srinagar.

These successes notwithstanding, by December the Indians were suffering from a paucity of logistical support and adequate high-